

Speed of Tape

Indicators & Analysis / Volume & Delta | intermediate | 4 min read | DeepCharts Help Center | August 24, 2026

Speed of Tape monitors the intensity of market activity — how much volume, how many orders, or how many trades go through in a fixed time window. When the tape speeds up, participants are urgent; when it slows to a crawl, nobody is committed. This indicator turns that tape-reading instinct into a measurable, chartable series.

It is a pace gauge rather than a direction gauge: it tells you how hard the market is working, and its candle-style coloring hints at which side is doing the work.

Get a feel for pace on the live tape below — let it run, then hover to pause and inspect individual prints while the buy/sell counters keep ticking.

[WIDGET: tape-lab]

What it is

The indicator measures activity per time interval — the **Number Seconds** window — using your choice of volume, orders, or executed trades as the input. The result plots as candlestick-style bars in a separate panel, with bull and bear coloring reflecting strong buyer or strong seller participation. Filters and a standard-deviation option let you keep only the statistically unusual readings.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Chart window with the Speed of Tape indicator in a footer panel — candlestick-style speed bars spiking during a breakout, with bull-colored bars on the impulse and smaller bars during the consolidation before it dc-en-speed-of-tape-01.png

When to use it

- You want early warning that activity is surging before a breakout extends — pace often rises with, or just before, the move.
- You identify acceleration patterns: successive speed increases confirm growing urgency behind a trend.
- You avoid dead markets: persistently low tape speed flags conditions where breakouts tend to fail.
- You supplement footprint or profile analysis with a pure pace dimension that neither shows directly.

Quick start

1. Open the **Indicator List** on your chart and add **Speed of Tape**.
2. Open the indicator's **Settings**.
3. Set **Input Data** to **Trades** to measure execution count, or keep **Volume** to weight by size (see Different Types of Input Data for Indicators).
4. Set **Number Seconds** to the interval you want speed measured over — shorter intervals react faster, longer intervals smooth the reading.
5. Leave **Filter Min** and **Filter Max** unset at first; add a **Filter Min** later to mark only genuinely fast periods.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Speed of Tape settings dialog open on the General section — Input Data dropdown expanded showing Volume, Order and Trades, with Number Seconds and the filter fields visible below dc-en-speed-of-tape-02.png

How to read it

- **Tall bars** — high activity for the measured window: urgency, participation, and usually cleaner follow-through.

- **Rising sequence of bars** — acceleration: each window is busier than the last, typical of a move gathering real participation.
- **Spike then collapse** — a burst that found no continuation; often marks climax or exhaustion points.
- **Bull-colored vs. bear-colored bars** — strong buyer participation versus strong seller participation, telling you which side generated the pace.
- **Flat, tiny bars** — the market is idling; treat range extremes and signals with extra skepticism until pace returns.

Settings reference

General

Setting	What it does
Input Data	What gets counted: Volume (amount of volume traded in the period), Order (number of orders placed during the period), or Trades (number of trades executed during the period).
Filter Min	Minimum threshold — only bars exceeding this level are marked.
Filter Max	Maximum threshold — only bars below this level are marked.
Number Seconds	The time interval (in seconds) in which speed is measured.
Std Dev Per Filter	Standard-deviation value for filtering data to a specific statistical range.

Subgraphs

Setting	What it does
Bull Border / Bull Fill	Colors for positive candles showing strong buyer participation.
Bear Border / Bear Fill	Colors for negative candles showing strong seller participation.
Subgraph Style	Drawing style — Candlesticks .
Line Style / Line Width	Rendering style and thickness.
Short Name	Custom label shown in the panel legend.

Tips and common mistakes

- **Choose the window deliberately.** A short **Number Seconds** value makes the panel twitchy; a long one hides micro-bursts. Match it to how long your typical trade setup takes to develop.
- **Speed is not direction.** A fast tape can be fast in both directions (a battle). Read pace here and direction from delta tools such as Delta Bar.
- **Use Std Dev Per Filter to find the unusual.** Filtering to readings beyond a statistical band keeps only the windows that genuinely deviate from normal pace, which is where the information is.
- **Combine, don't isolate.** The indicator is most effective alongside volume profile and delta analysis — pace confirms whether structure-based levels are being attacked with real participation.
- **Know the difference from the Instant variant.** Speed of Tape (Instant) focuses on the current, instantaneous tape speed over the most recent bars; this indicator plots the speed series across the chart's history.

Related articles

- Speed of Tape (Instant)

- Delta Bar
- Advanced Time And Sales (The Tape)
- Understanding Volume Profile: POC, Value Area, HVN/LVN
- Orderflow 101: Bid, Ask, Aggressor and Delta
- Different Types of Input Data for Indicators
- How to Change the Layout of Indicators